Japan instead is far more likely to take a middle path, improving its high-end defensive capabilities and modernizing its forces while maintaining political limits on what those forces can do. It is poised to export modest amounts of defense materials and engage in limited codevelopment and coproduction of armaments and assembly of major systems, such as the F-35 fighter. As for its security relationships, the alliance with the United States will remain at the center of Japan's security planning for the foreseeable future, with both Japanese policy makers and the public assuming that US forces will be the ultimate guarantor of the country's security in the case of a major conflict with China or North Korea.

Beyond that, future leaders who share Abe's vision likely will try to enhance relationships with key nations, including Australia and India, perhaps by joining in larger military drills and training. Meanwhile they will also ensure that smaller nations in Southeast Asia view Japan as a supplier of armaments. Doing so will indeed make Japan one of the more active regional actors in an Asia dominated by smaller and less developed nations. But Tokyo is unlikely to desire or sign any more mutual defense treaties, or to commit its forces in combat abroad. Even providing more public goods, such as conducting freedom of navigation operations in the South China Sea, will be difficult for a risk-averse government, as well as for a society that strongly distinguishes itself from the rest of the world.

A still-strong sense of being a country apart, a desire to maintain domestic social and political stability, and a wariness of draining national wealth on overseas interventions will continue to demarcate the limits of Japan's engagement with the world. As it has from time immemorial, the eightfold fence continues to ring, and to protect, the islands of Japan.

Notes

1. See, for example, Anthony W. Marx, *Faith in Nation: Exclusionary Origins of Nationalism* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2003).